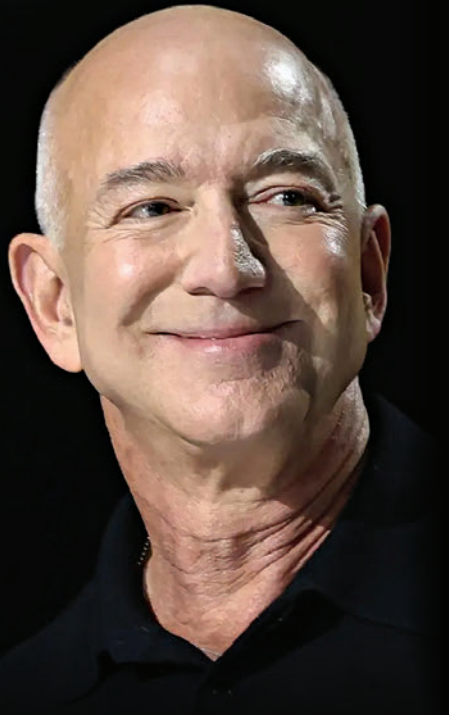


No Powerpoint allowed

How **Jeff Bezos** built Amazon with one simple rule

By **Madhav Banka** | editor@digit.in



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A typical meeting at any mega corporation is pretty common: a big boardroom, a glowing screen, and senior executives clicking through a PowerPoint presentation, mostly created by the overburdened juniors. It may work for others, but not for Amazon and Jeff Bezos.

And in 2004, Jeff Bezos had figured out this problem. He found that PowerPoint, and more specifically, the bullet-point system in any presentation, led to sloppy thinking. It simply allowed presenters to gloss over gaps with catchy phrases.

To tackle this, Bezos pulled off something that has never been seen before. He sent an internal email that would change corporate history forever, as he banned the usage of PowerPoint at the senior level. In its place, he proposed the idea that you had to write the entire thing down in a six-page narrative memo.

This idea helped shape Amazon as we know it today and is a big reason why they are able to move forward so fast. As Jeff Bezos says, *“Failure and invention are inseparable twins. To invent you have to experiment, and if you know in advance that it's going*

to work, it's not an experiment. Most large organizations embrace the idea of invention, but are not willing to suffer the string of failed experiments necessary to get there.”

In this edition of the Digit Game Changers, we examine Jeff Bezos' corporate strategy that still impacts the way Amazon operates till this day.

Bezos' switch to the six-page memos system

Bezos wanted to change how Amazon conducted meetings at the senior level. With the switch to the six-page memo system, he didn't just want meetings to start in a normal way. Rather, it was switched up, and instead of starting with a speech, they started with 30 minutes of silence. Where every person attending the meeting, including Bezos himself, would sit in the room and read the printed, six-page memo in total and complete silence.

And the philosophy behind this implementation was pretty simple: Bezos believed that quality writing is the way forward for quality thinking. Writing a narrative forces the author to understand and bridge the gap between ideas. By the time the